Nott maintaining that, now Jalalabad had been relieved and Akbar Khan defeated, they must begin winding-up operations and prepare to return to India, if necessary leaving the hostages and prisoners of war to their fate. The garrisons of Jalalabad and Kandahar could not believe that they were being forbidden to retake Kabul now that they had Akbar on the run. 'There seems to be some falability [sic] attending us in this country,' wrote Broadfoot when he heard the news. 'A vigorous advance on the Capital *now* would be certainly victorious and would almost as certainly lead to the entire submission of the Country . . . [But] the General has not instructions of any kind whatever from the government, and even if he could go on must halt from ignorance of the wishes of the Supreme authorities.'[11]

In Kandahar, Rawlinson – who was still agitating to have the whole of Afghanistan annexed to British India – was aghast when he read that Kandahar was now to be abandoned, along with the rest of the country. 'The peremptory order to retire has come upon us like a thunderclap,' he wrote. General Nott was even more frustrated that his moment of triumph was to be taken from him. 'The people in power are all mad,' he wrote to his daughters.

> Either that, or Providence hath blinded them for some wise purpose. I am very, very tired of working, tired of this country, and quite tired of the folly of my countrymen . . . My soldiers are four months in arrears; there is not one rupee in the Kandahar treasury, and no money can be borrowed. I have no medicine for the sick and wounded, I have no carriage cattle for the troops, nor money to buy or hire, and but little ammunition. I have been calling for all these for six months and not the least aid has been given to me . . . How I do long to be in some nice spot in Australia![12]

Unwilling to retreat, Generals Pollock and Nott both dragged their feet and sent to Ellenborough a long succession of excuses why they could not withdraw – the weather, lack of transport, money and so on – while they got the hawks in India and at home to lobby Ellenborough to change his mind. 'It is impossible to press upon you too strongly', wrote an all-too-willing Duke of Wellington to the Governor General, 'the notion of the importance of the restoration of reputation in the East.'[13] Pollock made the same point in a succession of letters to Calcutta, emphasising that 'with regard to our withdrawal at the present moment, I fear it would have the very worst effect; it would be construed into a defeat, and our character as a powerful nation would be entirely lost in this part of the world'.[14] Realising that he would be accused of throwing away an opportunity of freeing Akbar Khan's